Eisenhower administration had indeed envisioned exploiting Sino-Indian differences whenever feasible.[53] Now the administration saw US-India relations potentially benefiting from the Sino-Indian rift. It also proposed using the dispute for propaganda, for example, by highlighting to African countries considering recognizing the communist Chinese government how doing so had played out for Delhi.[54]

Furthermore, the administration hoped to use the Sino-Indian rift to generate support for India in the US. On Capitol Hill, officials noted that India had reacted "vigorously" to the Chinese crackdown in Tibet and now realized that China was aggressive and untrustworthy.[55] As the border dispute escalated and with a presidential visit to India forthcoming, the State Department policy planning director advocated "exploit[ing] the favorable public and congressional attitude toward India which are likely to result" to garner more aid for India.[56]

Some members of Congress, such as Representatives Dalip Singh Saund (D-CA) and Alvin Bentley (R-MI), saw the loss of Indian illusions about China as "the best thing that has happened in that part of the world." Representative William Poage (D-TX), after visiting India, believed that the Chinese actions could finally convince India that communism had to be resisted.[57] In public, too, there was much discussion of the impact on India's threat perception, some skepticism of whether Nehru's balancing act would work, continuing concern that Nehru would "appease" China, and the hope that India would lose its illusions about its northern neighbor.[58]

The administration was careful about its public response to the Sino-Indian dispute. It was aware of Indian anxieties about escalation. Initial US intelligence estimates had suggested that Beijing would "avoid drastic action" to avoid offending India. Once it became clear that this was a mistaken assessment, the administration felt that Chinese actions were having enough of an impact in India and the whole of Asia. Inflamed Indian public opinion, for example, had already forced Nehru's government to take a more assertive stance on Tibet.[59] An aggressive US response would only be counterproductive.

The administration thus did not want US officials or others like Jiang to take any action that would suggest that the uprising in Tibet was a Western or Taiwanese-instigated rebellion.[60] Washington instructed American officials in Delhi to take no action vis-à-vis the Tibetans streaming into